with strong interventions on disputes over natural resources, inconsistent messages on the peace process, and heavy silence on anti-Muslim violence in 2012 and 2013 (Chit Win 2016; also see Kean 2015).

Whether or not the legislature's non-partisanship successfully contained conflict, forced consensus — which is how I interpret it — is not democratic. Not only is it undemocratic in relation to those persons who were permitted to participate in some form but denied the opportunity to do so in a manner consistent with their aspirations, but also in relation to those persons who were entirely excluded who would otherwise also have become involved.[5] The creating of an appearance of consensus where people would otherwise have acted more antagonistically towards one another, given the opportunity, is what Mouffe wants to warn us against. Suppression of the political does not diminish or eliminate conflict. Instead it channels it into nonpolitical forms.

THE NONPOLITICAL

Melissa Crouch (2016) opens her discussion of the relationship between lawmaking and conflict in Myanmar with a quote from a widely read essay by Robert Cover (1986) on how law is constituted and reproduced through violence — what Walter Benjamin (1978) referred to as lawmaking and law-preserving violence (see also Derrida 1989). To the extent that law is made and remade through the process of interpretation, it depends upon violence for its own existence. And insofar as its response to conflict depends on violence it has certain inherently nonpolitical impulses. Law has the potential to foreclose on the possibility of the political by simple insistence that it be obeyed, on threat of violence for failure to comply.

Where legislative and executive functions are combined, as in Myanmar for the last half-century, the relationship of violence to law is fairly straightforward, insofar as the two are united in a single institution or person. Where some attempt is made to separate the two, even nominally, the relationship of law to violence becomes more problematic.

Crouch explores this uneasy relationship between violence and statute in post-2011 Myanmar. Some of the patterns in the writing of statues she identifies reveal a high degree of continuity with earlier periods, in which lawmaking was essentially an administrative process (see Cheesman 2015a). Other patterns, like new forms of consultation with community groups and